“I used to be in the textile trade, traveling salesman between Marseille and Orléans.” He looked behind him and all around. “But that work isn’t possible with the war.”

“Were you not mobilized to fight when the war broke out?”

“You ask a lot of questions, young lady.”

An awkward silence. The bluntness of his comment made her wonder if he was really here to help.

“I have three children and a wife with a heart problem, so I was exempt on compassionate grounds.”

Léa pushed open the door to the *chai* and waited for Monsieur Ferney to pass through before closing it behind her. She continued to pretend there were fermentation problems, thinking the Weinführer might question Ferney about her that day. Ferney didn’t seem to know about wine production; she wondered if he was searching for the rifles. “I think I’ve resolved the problem in two of the vats.”

“What problem?” He strode around the room, looking behind the vats.

“The fermentation had stopped in two vats, but I did as Monsieur LeBlanc advised this morning, and it’s working again. We can fill the barrels from the rest.” She fetched two large leather aprons hanging on the wall. Returning, she found he was gone.

“Monsieur Ferney?”

“I’m over here,” he called.

She walked past the vats to the back wall at the end of the *chai*. Her mouth dropped.

“You look like you’ve seen a ghost.” He laughed. “Got something to hide?”

“Nothing to hide.” She handed him one of the aprons. “I’ll show you what to do after you put this on.”

He leaned on the desk, his feet crossed on the carpet covering the entrance to the hatch.

“It’ll protect your clothing while we fill the barrels. Come on, they’re over here.”

They worked in silence the rest of the day. Ferney rolled the barrels to the vats, lifting them onto the rack as Léa opened the metal faucet so that the alcohol flowed through the bung hole. She let it spill over, as Édouard had taught her, then inserted a metal spigot to drain off the alcohol before